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INDIA-THAILAND DEFENCE DIALOGUE

Indian, Thai
officials talk
on bilateral,
defence ties

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The 10th Thailand-India Defence Dialogue was held in Bangkok on Tuesday with both the countries reviewing bilateral defence cooperation and exchanging views on regional and global security issues of mutual interest.

The dialogue was co-chaired by Thailand's Deputy Permanent Secretary for Defence, Admiral Nuttapol Diewvanich, and Joint Secretary in Defence Ministry Satyajit Mohanty.

According to the Ministry, both sides discussed the evolving security environment in the Indo-Pacific region and shared their perspectives on key regional developments. Defence industry cooperation featured prominently in the talks. They reaffirmed the importance of strengthening cooperation to promote stability and prosperity across the region.

INDIA-THAILAND DEFENCE DIALOGUE

- **Key Event**

- 10th India-Thailand Defence Dialogue held in Bangkok
- Co-chaired by Thailand's Deputy Permanent Secretary for Defence, Admiral Nuttapol Diewvanich, and India's Joint Secretary (Defence Ministry), Satyajit Mohanty

- **Agenda of the Dialogue**

- Review of bilateral defence cooperation between the two countries
- Exchange of views on regional and global security issues of mutual interest
- Discussion on the evolving security environment in the Indo-Pacific region
- Defence industry cooperation featured prominently in the talks

- **Strategic Significance**

- Reinforces India's Act East Policy and Indo-Pacific outreach
- Strengthens India-ASEAN strategic and defence-industrial engagement
- Aims to promote stability and prosperity across the wider region



Thailand

- **Chao Phraya River:** It flows through Bangkok, the capital city, and serves as a vital transportation route and source of water for irrigation.
- **Mekong River:** The Mekong forms a natural boundary between Thailand and Laos in the northeast region of Thailand. It is one of the longest rivers in Southeast Asia.
- **Countries: China, Myanmar, Laos, Thailand, Cambodia, Vietnam**
- Importance: One of the longest rivers in Asia, the Mekong is vital for transportation,
- **Irrawaddy River :** The Irrawaddy River, also known as the Ayeyarwady River, is the principal river and most important commercial waterway in Myanmar (Burma). Originating from the confluence of the N'mai and Mali rivers in Kachin State, it flows entirely through Myanmar from north to south before draining into the Andaman Sea via a large delta

ASEAN

Established in 1967 with the signing of the **Bangkok Declaration**

Motto : “One Vision, One Identity, One Community

Founding members of ASEAN: Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore and Thailand.

ASEAN Members: Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Vietnam and Timor-Leste.

ASEAN Secretariat: ASEAN Secretariat is located in Jakarta, Indonesia.



East Asia Summit

About East Asia Summit

Overview: A leaders-led forum for dialogue and cooperation on strategic, political, and economic issues to promote peace, stability, and prosperity in East Asia.

Genesis: Established in 2005, with the first Summit held in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia.

Nature: An annual meeting of Heads of State or Government of participating countries.

Members: ASEAN Member States, Australia, China, India, Japan, New Zealand, The Republic of Korea, United States and Russia.

RCEP

Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP)

It is a comprehensive free trade agreement among 15 Asia-Pacific countries.

Members: 10 ASEAN Member States - Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, and Vietnam along with five of ASEAN's major trade partners: Australia, China, Japan, South Korea, and New Zealand.

India withdrew from the RCEP negotiations in 2019.

Home > UPSC Prelims > Previous Year Question Paper > 2026 > Which of the following...

QUESTION

GS

Medium

International Relations

Prelims 2026

Which of the following connectivity projects is/are a part of cooperation between India and the ASEAN member countries ?

1. Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project
2. IMT Trilateral Highway
3. Agartala-Akhaura Rail Line

Select the answer using the code given below :

Select an option to attempt

☐ A 1 and 2

☐ B 2 and 3

☐ C 1 and 3

☐ D 2 only

The term 'Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership; often appears in the news in the context of the affairs of a group of countries known as

This question was previously asked in

**Official UPSC Civil Services
Exam 2016 Prelims Part A**

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1. G20

2. ASEAN

3. SCO

4. SAARC

SC's ECONOMIC VALUATION OF UNPAID DOMESTIC WORK

Step forward

The top court has given an economic value to unpaid domestic work

The Supreme Court's judgment in *Shishu-pal Gishik-Ram vs Surjit* by a Division Bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N.K. Singh, is likely a landmark. The ruling originated as the Court revised compensation granted by the Motor Accident Claims Tribunal (MACT) for a road accident in 2001. The first MACT awarded the family of Reshma, the accident victim, ₹2.42 lakh, which the Punjab and Haryana High Court revised in 2024 to ₹8.43 lakh. But in its order, the Court revised it to ₹62.78 lakh after attaching a sum of ₹30,000 a month to Ms. Reshma's 'economic value', for the service she rendered as a homemaker. The ruling is not surprising. In *Lata Wadhwa* (2000), the Court valued a homemaker's services at a modest ₹3,000. In *Kirti vs Oriental Insurance* (2021), it said the economic value of a homemaker's work cannot be discounted simply because it is unpaid or performed by women. However, the 'official' value attached to that work has suffered from inconsistent quantification. The Bench's value of ₹30,000 a month is itself notional and a floor; it added that the floor must be hiked by 10% every three years and a woman's salary, where applicable, has to be added to the floor, in the context of MACT's claims. The judgment does not create a salary, wage entitlement, pension scheme or employment relationship for homemakers, and applies to compensation calculations in MACT cases only. That said, the now-normalised societal tendency to undervalue women's work means that any advance is valuable and will likely have ripple effects.

The connection between unpaid domestic labour and suppressed female labour force participation is a major theme in contemporary Indian labour economics. Now, for example, homemakers seeking maintenance under the Hindu Marriage Act, say, have judicial reasoning supporting the economic value of their domestic work. Rural women who "assist in sowing, harvesting, and cattle-tending", as the Court noted, can now invoke the Court's reasoning to pitch to have their labour, which is often treated as being incidental to household work, valued higher. The additive rule may encourage litigants to invoke similar reasoning in employment disputes *vis-à-vis* 'work from home' arrangements and domestic responsibilities. Future litigation may test whether male homemakers can claim equivalent treatment. Motor insurance is already a low-margin segment for many insurers, and a large increase in the average claim size – likely applied retrospectively as well – may force companies to reassess their risk models and render them more inclined to settle claims quickly in Lok Adalats. All said, the Shishupal judgment is a vital corrective to decades of economic erasure.

SC's ECONOMIC VALUATION OF UNPAID DOMESTIC WORK

● **Background of the Judgment**

- SC Division Bench (Justices Sanjay Karol & N.K. Singh) revised MACT compensation in Shishupal @ Shish Ram vs Surjeet (2001 road accident case)
- Compensation rose from Rs.2.42 lakh (MACT) to Rs.8.43 lakh (P&H High Court, 2024) to Rs.62.78 lakh (Supreme Court)

● **Economic Valuation of Homemaker's Work**

- Court attached a notional value of Rs.30,000/month to the homemaker's unpaid domestic services
- This floor must be hiked by 10% every three years; any actual salary earned is to be added to the floor

● **Scope and Limitations**

- Applies only to compensation calculations under Motor Accident Claims Tribunal (MACT) cases
- Does not create a salary, wage entitlement, pension scheme or employment relationship for homemakers

● **Broader Significance**

Links unpaid domestic labour to suppressed female labour force participation in India

May influence maintenance claims under the Hindu Marriage Act and valuation of rural women's agricultural work

Likely to push motor insurers toward faster settlement of claims via Lok Adalats

SC's ECONOMIC VALUATION OF UNPAID DOMESTIC WORK

Where to Apply

- **Prelims** : Landmark Supreme Court judgments on gender justice; Motor Vehicles Act and MACT compensation provisions.
- **Mains** : GS Paper 1 (Role of Women, Unpaid Care Work) / GS Paper 2 (Judiciary and Social Justice) - 'Monetising unpaid domestic work and its link to female labour force participation.'
- **Interview** : Should housework be monetised by law?

INDIA-RUSSIA LOGISTICS AGREEMENT (RELOS)

What does the India-Russia logistics agreement allow?

What is RELOS, and does it allow India and Russia to station troops on each other's territory?

Dinakar Peri

The story so far:

The India-Russia bilateral Logistics Support Agreement (LSA), termed the Reciprocal Exchange of Logistics Agreement (RELOS), which had been dragging on for several years, was operationalised in January this year. There was a flutter on social media recently with claims that it allows the stationing of 3,000 Russian troops on Indian soil or vice versa, painting it as a military alliance. However, it is like any LSA, the likes of which India has signed with other countries.

What are Logistics Support Agreements?

A logistics agreement is a foundational military cooperation agreement between

countries for administrative purposes that enables the reciprocal use of each other's bases and ports for supplies, repair, and fuel. The agreement also stipulates the occasions on which this can be utilised, generally for exercises, joint training, port calls, and Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief situations. As defence cooperation and military-to-military engagement become vital in international relations, the agreement simplifies essential administrative procedures and reduces bureaucracy.

For instance, the agreement with the U.S., Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (LEMOA) signed in 2016, the first such, provides a framework for reciprocal provision of logistic support, supplies and services for activities such as joint exercises, training, or humanitarian assistance and disaster relief. "It does not provide for the establishment of any

bases or basing arrangements," Minister of State for Defence Subhash Bhamre said in a written reply in the Parliament in February 2017.

If the hyperbole is to be believed, India and Russia can station troops on each other's territory, then by convention, it also means that India and the U.S. can do the same under the LEMOA. But that is grossly incorrect, as clarified by the Minister, and is so for any LSA.

What are the existing agreements?

India has signed a series of logistics support agreements since the LEMOA in 2016. Currently, India has similar agreements with nine countries – the U.S., the U.K., France, Vietnam, Japan, Australia, Singapore, and Russia – concluded on similar lines, which provide logistics support and technical aid. The basic template and purpose for all these

remain the same. There is also one with Oman covered under the overarching defence cooperation agreement.

What is the agreement with Russia?

Like other agreements, RELOS defines procedures for supporting military formations, port calls of warships, and the use of airspace and airfield facilities by military aircraft of both countries and the organisation of logistics and technical support of military formations of warships, military aircraft, and other equipment.

The agreement was signed in Moscow on February 18, 2025, and Russian President Vladimir Putin signed the federal law ratifying it on December 15, 2025. According to the Kremlin, the purpose of the agreement is to define the procedures for the deployment of military formations, port calls by warships, and the use of airspace and airfield infrastructure by military aircraft of the two countries.

Broadly, RELOS covers joint military exercises, training, HADR missions, port and repair services, medical support, as well as delivery of food and technical resources and reciprocal access to military facilities, including airbases and ports, to support ship and aircraft personnel.

The agreement stipulates a maximum

of 3,000 troops, representing a broad upper limit that takes into account the size of contingents and the number of ships or aircraft that may visit during engagements mutually agreed upon by both sides. It is valid for a period of five years, allowing for revisions later to reflect changing circumstances and requirements. The time frame for positioning of assets and personnel would be subject to the visit mutually agreed upon by both parties, one official said.

In fact, the scale of bilateral and multilateral relations between India and other countries is much larger. Indian armed forces exercise with the U.S. now.

Also, the agreement does not confer any provision for permanent basing of assets, and the agreement shall be exercised during joint exercises, port calls, or visits mutually agreed by both nations based on provisions of the agreement, officials clarified. "No permanent or long-term stationing has been agreed upon as part of the Agreement."

One important aspect is that RELOS gives access to Russian military facilities in the Arctic as both countries expand cooperation there, as new navigation routes open up, a fallout of global warming.

(Dinakar Peri is Fellow, Security Studies at Carnegie India)

INDIA-RUSSIA LOGISTICS AGREEMENT (RELOS)

- **What is RELOS**

- Reciprocal Exchange of Logistics Support Agreement - India-Russia bilateral Logistics Support Agreement (LSA), operationalised in January 2026

- Signed in Moscow on February 18, 2025; ratified by Russian federal law on December 15, 2025

- **What It Allows**

- Reciprocal use of bases and ports for supplies, repair and fuel during exercises, joint training, port calls and HADR operations
 - Simplifies administrative procedures and reduces bureaucracy in military-to-military engagement
 - Valid for five years with provision for revision; sets an upper administrative limit of around 3,000 troops

- **Important Clarifications**

- Does NOT permit permanent or long-term stationing of troops on each other's territory
 - Does NOT confer any provision for permanent basing of military assets

- **India's Other Logistics Agreements**

- LEMOA with the USA (2016) was the first such agreement for India
 - India now has similar logistics agreements with nine countries - US, UK, France, Vietnam, Japan, Australia, Singapore, Russia and Oman

HEALTH DATA MUST DRIVE ACTION, NOT JUST HEADLINES

Health data must drive action, not just headlines

There is an unsettling paradox in the release of health survey data in India. Survey findings often end up doing exactly the reverse of what they should. They often highlight what we already know, do not take a sufficiently serious view of what has not improved, and rarely lead to immediate programmatic action. The discussion that follows is often ritualistic: the government highlights achievements, newspapers amplify numbers, academics wait for raw data to analyse, and business and industry identify market opportunities.

This seems to be the case with the three recently released health-linked surveys: the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6), the National Statistical Office (NSO) 80th Round Household Consumption on Health and the National Health Accounts Estimates for India 2022-23.

All three should have offered a moment of national stocktaking. Instead, the two reports on health expenses barely received any attention, while the third, the NFHS-6, and its use by key stakeholders, tells a familiar story. In government communication, improvements have been selected and celebrated. Achievements must, of course, be acknowledged. However, the real value of such surveys is not in confirming what has worked, but in showing where programmes remain weak and old strategies are no longer sufficient.

The business of disease

Industry and business groups have flagged rising health challenges reported in NFHS-6. Rising obesity becomes an argument for weight-loss products, apps, gyms, diagnostics and drugs. Rising diabetes becomes an opportunity for monitoring devices, test packages and private clinics. Rising non-communicable diseases become the market case for more screening, testing and medicalisation. Where public health messaging is weak and private health markets are aggressive, every survey finding can become a business prospect.

The one positive development so far has been the extensive coverage in the print media, which has flagged what matters to citizens: the rise of obesity, diabetes, hypertension and other non-communicable diseases (NCD). Yet, much of this was already known. Obesity and other NCDs have moved from urban and affluent groups to all social and economic groups. The new data merely put fresh numbers to an old warning.

What is grossly missing is critical reflection and policy dialogue around these findings. This should worry us. A health survey is not meant to be a national reminder of familiar problems but an instrument of course correction. If anaemia



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has not improved, the response cannot be another paragraph in a report. If out-of-pocket expenditure remains high, the answer cannot be only a headline on a declining percentage share. If obesity is rising among children, the response cannot be a few articles followed by silence.

The NFHS-6 also carries a temporal problem. Its data were collected during 2022-24, but the findings entered public debate in mid-2026. In a political system skilled at both claiming credit and avoiding blame, this lag is convenient. A government can celebrate positive indicators as proof of current policy success while dismissing uncomfortable findings as "old data", influenced by the COVID-19 pandemic, past administrative disruptions or conditions that have since improved. The survey then becomes less a compass and more a weapon. This is unfair to the survey and unhelpful to policymaking.

Academics and public health researchers play a crucial role in interpreting large-scale survey data beyond official reports. In India, however, such analysis is often delayed because raw data are released late. By the time peer-reviewed studies appear, three to five years may have passed since data collection. Policymakers can then dismiss critical findings as outdated and no longer relevant. As a result, data lose their impact: when reports are released, raw data are unavailable for scrutiny; when analysis finally arrives, the opportunity for policy action has often passed.

From data to action

There is a need to reflect on how India continues to miss these opportunities. Data improve health outcomes only when they are linked to timely and relevant policy decisions. Countries that make effective use of health data do not wait years for perfect academic papers or definitive solutions. Instead, they have robust systems and empowered institutions that generate rapid policy briefs, identify lagging districts and regions, conduct regular reviews, compare performance, allocate resources efficiently and adapt programmes as needed. The translation of data into action is not merely a slogan; it is a discipline. India needs to cultivate that discipline if it is to realise the full value of the vast amounts of health data it collects.

First, every major national health survey should be followed, within 30 to 45 days, by a national and State-level action note jointly prepared by the government and independent academic institutions. The note should candidly identify what has improved, what has remained stagnant and what has deteriorated. Each finding should be linked to a specific programme and a clearly accountable authority. If child nutrition has stagnated, the nutrition programme must

respond. If hypertension detection remains inadequate, the primary health-care system must respond. If out-of-pocket expenditure on medicines remains high, the drug procurement system must respond. Data should not merely describe problems; they should trigger accountability and corrective action.

Second, there should be State-level health data review meetings, not ceremonial events but working sessions. Health Secretaries, Finance Departments, District officials, public health experts, civil society representatives, other key stakeholders and independent subject experts should examine the findings together. The question should not be, "What can we highlight?" It should be, "What must we change?"

Third, India needs systems for the optimal and timely use of survey data. It has started developing the Integrated Health Information Platform (IHIP), but that is primarily for real-time data. Survey Data, Health Management Information System (HMIS) data and IHIP data must be combined to generate analytical information. Fragmented data produce fragmented policy.

Fourth, primary data and source files from surveys should be made available early so that independent researchers and public institutions can produce quick analysis. There is no reason to wait years for serious interpretation. Data should not sit like a guarded file. They should be available as a public good.

Fifth, findings should influence budgetary allocation. If a survey shows rising NCDs, primary care budgets must reflect the need for NCD prevention and treatment. If households are spending heavily on medicines, public facilities must strengthen essential drug availability. If obesity is rising in children, school health, food regulation and urban planning must respond. Data without budgetary consequence are merely information.

Looking ahead

Economist Aaron Levenstein said in 1951 that "statistics are like bikinis. What they reveal is suggestive, but what they conceal is vital". Health data should be like an x-ray. They are useful only when interpreted correctly, discussed honestly and followed by policy actions. Data and statistics are only as useful as their interpretation; interpretation is only as useful as the action it produces. The next time survey findings are released, the real question should not be what the numbers show. The real question should be: what will change in programmes in a month's time, in six months and in a year? Alongside this, India definitely needs more and timely health data. However, what we need even more is accountability.

Health data should guide accountability, budgets and programme reform

HEALTH DATA MUST DRIVE ACTION, NOT JUST HEADLINES

● Recent Health Surveys in Focus

- National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6)
- NSO 80th Round Household Consumption Survey on Health
- National Health Accounts (NHA) Estimates for India, 2022-23

● Key Issue Highlighted

- Survey data often confirms known facts but rarely translates into timely programmatic or policy action
- Rising Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs) such as obesity, diabetes and hypertension risk being commercialised rather than addressed through public health response
- Temporal lag - NFHS-6 data collected in 2023-24 entered public debate only in mid-2026, letting governments dismiss findings as 'old data'

HEALTH DATA MUST DRIVE ACTION, NOT JUST HEADLINES

● Suggested Reforms

- National and State-level action notes within 30-45 days of every major survey, jointly prepared by government and independent academic institutions
- Regular, working-style State-level health data review meetings involving Health Secretaries, Finance Departments and district officials
- Early public release of raw data and source files to enable independent, timely analysis
- Direct linkage of survey findings to budgetary allocation for health programmes

● Bottom Line

- 'Data without budgetary consequence are merely information' - health data must trigger accountability and corrective action, not just headlines

GENDER QUOTA TO BREAK GLASS CEILING IN JUDICIARY



JAYNA KOTHARI

A gender quota to break glass ceiling in judiciary

JUNE 2 was a proud and emotional day for women lawyers as we witnessed the appointment of Justice V Mohana, only the second woman from the Bar to be appointed directly to the Supreme Court. The battle for women in India to reach the higher echelons in the legal profession has been anything but easy. For women lawyers to become judges of the Supreme Court of India is a glass ceiling that has not been shattered yet. The Court has appointed nine male judges directly from the Bar. They all had long tenures, with Justice S M Sikri and Justice UU Lalit becoming chief justices, and current appointees Justice P S Narasimha and Justice K V Viswanathan also due to become chief justices. Justice Indu Malhotra, who was the first woman lawyer directly appointed to the Supreme Court in 2018, had a tenure of less than three years, due to which she did not even become part of the Collegium.

Jurisdictions the world over are bringing structural constitutional reforms to ensure gender equality in their highest courts. In 2014, Belgium passed an amendment modifying Article 34(5) of the Special Act of 6 January 1989 concerning its constitutional court. This amendment introduced a gender quota mandating that at least one-third of the 12 judges must belong to each sex. Till the court reached the composition of

All the recent appointments of male judges were made based on such representation. Then why not a quota to ensure 33.3 per cent gender representation?

one-third women judges, it was mandated that after every two male appointees, the third appointment would have to be of a woman. The Belgian constitutional court also has linguistic and professional quotas for judges.

In South Africa, Section 174 (2) of the constitution mandates that the judiciary must reflect the country's racial and gender composition. Currently, six of the South African constitutional court's 11 judges are women, making it one of the first women-majority constitutional courts anywhere in the world, and it has a woman chief justice.

Quotas for representation are not new. Even in our Supreme Court, appointments of judges are made keeping in mind the representation from different high courts. All the recent appointments of male judges were made based on such representation. Then why not a quota to ensure 33.3 per cent gender representation?

Even with the appointment of Justice Mohana, the percentage of women in our Supreme Court is a woeful 5.4 per cent, with only two women judges out of 37. Meanwhile, the proportion of women judges in the most progressive supreme courts is moving towards 50 per cent and ensuring that at least 33.3 per cent are women. 54.5 per cent of the judges of South Africa's constitutional court are women, as are 50 per cent of the

judges in Canada, Belgium, and Germany's top courts. The figure is 44.4 per cent for the US, 42.85 for Australia and 33.33 per cent for France. Meanwhile, Singapore falls below the 33 per cent mark with around 24 per cent of its SC judges being women, and Nepal and the UK fare even worse at roughly 17 per cent each.

Measures have to be taken for equal representation of women in India's Supreme Court. This needs the targeted inclusion of women from the Bar, from minority faiths, and from SC/ST and OBC communities. Ideally, an amendment to Articles 124 and 217 of the Constitution would be required to direct that appointments of judges to the SC and HCs should reflect the gender and caste composition of the country. Till this is done, the SC needs to introduce a stated written policy to have 33.3 per cent women on the Court, which will direct targeted appointments. We can adopt the easy strategy used in Belgium, that after every two appointments of male judges in the Court, the next appointment must be of a woman till we reach 33.3 per cent.

While we take pride in Justice Mohana's appointment, we have to work towards getting an equal number of women judges on the Supreme Court of our country and build a road map to get there.

The writer is a senior advocate, Supreme Court of India, and executive director, Centre for Law & Policy Research

GENDER QUOTA TO BREAK GLASS CEILING IN JUDICIARY

● Recent Development

- **Appointment of Justice V. Mohana** - only the second woman lawyer directly appointed to the Supreme Court (after Justice Indu Malhotra in 2018)
- **Even after this appointment, women form only 5.4% of Supreme Court judges (2 out of 37)**

● Comparative Global Practice

- **Belgium (2014):** Constitutional amendment mandates one-third women judges - every third appointment after two male appointees must be a woman
- **South Africa:** Constitution (Article 174(2)) mandates that the judiciary reflect the country's racial and gender composition; 6 of 11 constitutional court judges are women
- **Share of women judges in top courts:** about 33% in Canada, Belgium and Germany; 44.4% in the US; 42.85% in Australia; 33.33% in France; India trails far behind at 5.4%

GENDER QUOTA TO BREAK GLASS CEILING IN JUDICIARY

● Proposed Reforms for India

- Targeted inclusion of women from the Bar, minority faiths and SC/ST/OBC communities
- Constitutional amendment to Articles 124 and 217 to mandate representative judicial appointments
- Adopt a 'Belgian-style' rule - every third appointment after two male judges to be a woman, until 33.3% representation is achieved

● Significance

- Greater diversity on the bench strengthens legitimacy, representativeness and substantive equality in justice delivery

Thank You